Behavior Change Project Instructions

The behavior change project is based on a goal that each student will set and implement. The topic of the project MUST be one of the following topics: physical activity, sleep, nutrition, social media use, or fluid intake.

The project is broken into the following steps:

Step 1: SMART goal and data collection plan– submitted in class activity for September 9th

Step 2: Background research – September 10-19th

Step 3: Data Collection – September 21st – September 25th

Step 4: Complete Poster – September 27th – October 2nd

Step 5: Recorded Presentation – due October 7th

	September – October						
Week	**Sunday**	**Monday**	**Tuesday**	**Wednesday**	**Thursday**	**Friday**	**Saturday**
1	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
2	13	14	15	16	17	18	19
3	20	21	22	23	24	25	26
4	27	28	29	30	1	2	3
5	4	5	6	7	8	9	10

Step 1: SMART Goal and Data Collection Plan

Students will read an article on SMART goals, learn about shaping behavior as a class lecture, then decide which behavior they would like to change. Students will use this material to create their SMART goals. Next, students will come up with a plan for how they will measure their variables and collect data. Students will submit the goal and plan as the Shaping Health Behaviors activity. Students are required to review any feedback on these goals/ plans before beginning data collection and reach out ASAP if they have any concerns about the potential adjustments.

SMART Goal

A SMART goal is specific, measurable, attainable, relevant, and timebound. **Be sure to address each aspect of the SMART goal guidelines to receive full credit**.

- State your goal, and explain how it addresses each aim of the SMART Goal design
    - My goal: "I will insure I get 8 hours of sleep every night by going to bed by 11 pm."
    - Specific: I will get 8 hours of sleep between 11pm and 7 am.
    - Measurable: I will keep a log of when I go to sleep and wake up.
    - Achievable: I typically go to bed at 12:30am, so without 90 minutes of doom scrolling, I will be able to go to sleep by 11pm.

    - Relevant: By sleeping more, I will increase my concentration in class.
    - Timebound: I will follow this plan every night on a daily basis for 1 week.
- **BE VERY SPECIFIC**. If your goal is to reduce sugar, what is your goal number of grams to stay under? If you want to exercise, is there a certain level of intensity necessary to be considered necessary (any activity that involves movement? Heart rate above a certain level, as measured by your watch?). The more specific you are, the more prepared you will be, and the better the implementation of the plan.

Data Collection Plan

- This section will address how you will collect **<u>and</u>** how you will record data.
- **<u>Be very thorough</u> (even more thorough than you will be in your poster)**
- For planning how you will collect your data…
    - Think about how you will operationally define your task. If your goal is to exercise, what qualifies as "exercise"? Walking? Cardio at the gym? Lifting weights?
    - Use how you define your topic to inform how you will measure the behavior, as that will drastically impact your collection style.
    - For example, if your goal is to reduce sugar intake, and you define "sugar intake" as consuming candy/ bakery items, your collection plan could include…
        - "I will reduce all sugar-based treats from my diet. I will record the number of times I have a sweet treat each day in an excel sheet. In this same excel sheet, I will also track my total number of healthy snacks. For each day, I will calculate a ratio of number of treats to my number of healthy snacks, to track if I am shifting my snacking habits towards healthier options, with less sugar. By shifting towards a healthy snack, I will limit my chance of relapsing and eating sugar when I get hungry."
    - Alternatively, if you define "sugar intake" as any processed sugar included in all foods
        - "I will reduce all processed sugar in my diet. I will record the grams of sugar in every meal I eat. To facilitate this, I will use the app 'MyNetDiary' to calculate how much sugar is in each meal, then keep a log of each meal's sugar consumption in an excel sheet. By increasing my awareness of the amount of sugar in the meals I consume regularly, I will be able to make more informed dietary choices moving forward. This knowledge will help me maintain a diet with a limited amount of sugar."
- For planning how you will record your day…
    - Consider things like what apps and formats will be most helpful. Will you need a table? A list with a value per day? What information will you collect each day?

- For example, if you are recording your diet, one approach would be to use a table, where you have a column for each, a row for each meal, and in each cell, you record your total sugar intake.
- Alternatively, you could record your diet using a series of lists in a Word document, where you have a heading for every day, with bullet points for each food item you ate that day listed.

Step 2: Background Research

In this stage, you will conduct background research on your topic. This section needs to be based on at least THREE **peer-reviewed** articles. If you are unsure how to access peer-reviewed journal articles through the UNK library database, or if you need a refresher on where to get information for citing your sources, please see the "Accessing Journal Articles" document in the Behavior Change Project page on Canvas. If you are unsure if an article is considered peer-reviewed, please have Dr. Scheuler check it ASAP (only peer-reviewed sources will count towards the three you need). Each article used **must** have an in-text citation and a listing in the references. For information on writing up the background research, please see the instructions for the background section of the poster. For information on citing your sources, please see the instructions for the references section of the poster.

Step 3: Data Collection

For one week, you will follow your data collection plan, keeping thorough record of your ability to maintain your behavior change. If you deviate from the plan (ex: twisting an ankle and being unable to workout), it is important to make note of what changed and why.

Step 4: Behavior Change Poster

The poster will provide an overview of the entire project, in a format similar to a conference poster. It will include 1) a brief summary of the research on the behavior and how it impacts health, 2) a brief explanation of the rationale explaining student's rationale for choosing the behavior, 3) the SMART goal and an explanation of how it meets each of the SMART guidelines, 4) an explanation of the data collection plan, 5) an overview of the results, including a graph or table, 6) a review of AI feedback and the possibility for implementation, 7) are project reflection and conclusion, and 8) APA references. A template is provided in Canvas, so students can edit directly into the PowerPoint document, without needing to change the formatting. Additionally, an example poster is provided in Canvas, so students have a visual for a completed poster.

The Topic Background Section (15 points)

The first section in the poster should be a review of AT LEAST three **peer-reviewed** articles. Each article referenced must have an in-text citation and a listing in the references. Use

your references to illustrate that your points are based on science and not opinion. This section should be written in the student's own words, with NO direct quotes. Throughout this paragraph, it should be clear that changing the behavior is directly related to shaping health outcomes, and is not just a change made by chance. Note: You may use an image/ SmartArt design in this section, but it is not required (but, you must create it, rather than chance copyright infringement).

A note on in-text citations for this section:

- In APA, there are two forms of in-text citation: narrative and parenthetical
    - Narrative: When the in-text citation is used in the sentence
    - Example: Scheuler (2025) established that health psychology is a great field by …
    - Parenthetical: When the sentence does not mention the source, the citation is listed at the end of the sentence that references the material.
    - Example: Health psychology is a crucial field (Scheuler, 2025).
- There are slight variations in citation structure based on number of authors, but in each case, the in-text citation will include the author information and the date published
    - One author:
        - Narrative: Scheuler (2025)
        - Parenthetical: (Scheuler, 2025)
    - Two authors:
        - Narrative: Scheuler and Turner (2025)
        - Parenthetical: (Scheuler & Turner, 2025)
    - Three or more authors:
        - Narrative: Scheuler et al. (2025) OR Scheuler and colleagues (2025) [or other variations on colleagues/ fellow researchers/ associates/ etc.]
        - Parenthetical: (Scheuler et al., 2025)
- For more on in-text citations, see: https://apastyle.apa.org/style-grammar-guidelines/citations

Points in Rubric:

Excellent – 15 pts	**Proficient – 12 pts**	**Developing – 9 pts**	**Needs Improvement – 6 pts or below**
-Research paragraph(s) utilizes ≥3 peer-reviewed articles with accurate APA in-text citations; written fully in student's own words (no direct quotes). Clearly addresses why the behavior matters for health	-Uses 3 peer-reviewed articles, but the explanations are too brief OR citations are not clearly connected to health outcomes. -In students' own words, but includes content that should be	-Only uses 2 peer-reviewed articles OR includes 3 citations, but less than 3 are peer-reviewed. -Does not clearly connect behavior to health relevance. -Multiple statements that should be backed with citation.	-Uses 0-1 peer-reviewed articles. -Includes direct quotes. -The majority of the research background is missing adequate citations OR largely opinion-based.

Excellent – 15 pts	Proficient – 12 pts	Developing – 9 pts	Needs Improvement – 6 pts or below
outcomes (science-based, not opinion).	backed with a citation.		

Personal Rationale (5 points)

The second section will explain why you were interested in making the behavior change. This section will answer the question, "Why did you choose this behavior to change?" You may want to address things like direct impact to daily life, family history, or reaching specific goals.

Points in Rubric:

Excellent – 5 pts	Proficient – 4 pts	Developing – 3 pts	Needs Improvement – 2 pts or below
-Clearly explains personal rationale for choosing the behavior (specific, thoughtful, relevant).	-Personal rationale present but could be clearer or better integrated.	-Personal rationale is too brief or unclear.	-Personal rationale section is missing or does not relate to the health behavior.

SMART Goal (10 points)

This section should be at least one paragraph (all complete sentences), explicitly stating your goal, and describing how that goal meets SMART guidelines. Be sure that you address EACH of the five guidelines **separately**.

Points in Rubric:

Excellent – 10 pts	Proficient – 8 pts	Developing – 6 pts	Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below
-Goal is clearly stated and explicitly addresses all 5 SMART elements (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound) separately in complete sentences.	-Goal is clear; addresses all SMART elements but one element is underdeveloped or blended together.	-Goal stated but misses 1–2 SMART elements OR elements are too vague to describe the goal.	-Goal is unclear/ unmeasurable, or does not follow SMART structure.

Data Collection Plan (5 points)

In this section, you will explain how you collected your data (it is essentially the methods section of a research paper). How did you measure your health behavior? What are all the aspects you measured? How did you collect your data? Be sure that you are clarifying your units in this section. If you are using any specific apps/ websites/ platforms, you need to explain it in this section. Additionally, you should not have any information in the results section that is not first introduced in the data collection section.

Points in Rubric:

Excellent –5 pts	Proficient – 4 pts	Developing – 3 pts	Needs Improvement – 2 pts or below
-Clearly explains how data were collected, what was measured, and tools/approach used.	-Data collection and results are described, but missing details (e.g., units, measurement specifics).	-Partial description of collection methods; results listed without explanation in plan.	-Little clarity on how data were collected

Results (10 points)

What were the results of your behavior change? This section needs to include the key results in sentence or bullet form, and provide a visual of your results. The written section of the results should address all areas you assessed, and make note of any material that was not able to be measured (and why, if there is a reason). The visual can be a table or a graph, and must contribute to the understanding of the project. All text must be legible, so be very cognizant of

space on the poster when designing your visual. Do not forget to include units for your behavior (cups for water, hours for sleep, etc.). Please see the example poster for an idea of what this visual could look like.

Points in Rubric:

Excellent – 10 pts	**Proficient – 8 pts**	**Developing – 6 pts**	**Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below**
5 points: -Clearly explains key results. Includes units (e.g., cups, minutes, steps). 5 points: -Includes a table or figure with all units and labels.	4 points: -Results are described, but missing details (e.g., units, measurement specifics). 4 points: -Figure/table present but missing units OR labels	3 points: -Results vague or missing key outcomes. 3 points: -Figure/table missing units AND labels	-Little clarity on how data were collected or what the results mean. -Figure/table missing, too blurry to see, or not clearly related to behavior.

AI Feedback (10 points)

For this section, you will request feedback on your project from a generative AI platform such as Copilot or ChatGPT. Here is an example of the prompt you could enter into AI (feel free to edit this example to match your project):

> For a health psychology class, I attempted to change a health-related behavior. The behavior I wanted to change was increasing the amount of intentional time I spent spoiling my cats each day. The SMART goal I set was to spend at least 30 minutes per day, for five days, intentionally engaging in spoiling activities (such as brushing, playing, cuddle time without distractions, and treat-based enrichment) over a one-week intervention period. To measure the behavior change over seven days, I tracked the total number of minutes spent in intentional, distraction-free interaction with my cats each evening using a spreadsheet. Additionally, I recorded my happiness ratings on a scale of 1-10. I was successful at increasing my daily average from approximately 15 minutes at baseline to 32 minutes during the intervention week, meeting or exceeding my 30-minute goal on four of five days. I struggled with consistency on particularly busy workdays, when I fell slightly short of my target. If I were to repeat the study, how could I improve my approach to make this behavior more sustainable and easier to maintain long term?

After receiving feedback on your project from the AI platform, you will summarize the feedback the platform suggested IN YOUR OWN WORDS. After briefly describing the feedback, you will address if you believe that you could implement the suggestions, and if they would improve your success. Be sure to use in-text citations when referencing the platform, and include a listing in the references. See below for an example reference:

ChatGPT. (2025, September 28). *Citing ChatGPT in APA for beginners* [generative AI chat]. ChatGPT. https://chatgpt.com/c/68da0b8e-bfbc-8321-a026-825dcc2ee250

As a note, you can read more about the guidelines on APA citation at the following link: https://apastyle.apa.org/blog/cite-generative-ai-references

Points in Rubric:

Excellent – 10 pts	**Proficient – 8 pts**	**Developing – 6 pts**	**Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below**
7 points: -Poster includes a clear summary in student's own words or AI suggestions, and addresses the feasibility/impact of suggestions. 3 points: -Correct in-text citations and listing in references	6 points: -AI suggestions OR implementation is too brief. 2 point: -Minor errors in in-text citation and/ or references.	5 points: -Missing either suggestion or implementation. 1 point: missing in-text citation OR listing in reference	-AI feedback is not meaningfully addressed. -In-text citations and reference listing are missing.

Project Reflection and Conclusion (10 points)

In this section, you will reflect on the entire project, addressing each of the following questions.

- What aspects led to the overall success (or lack thereof) of your behavior change?
- What would you do differently to make this behavior change into a health habit? (Note: consider things like modifying your goal, adjust how you measured the behavior, or implementing a different reward system).
- What did you learn about yourself and/ or the health behavior?

After reflecting on your experience, you will write a brief conclusion (2-3 sentences) summarizing the project.

Points in Rubric:

Excellent – 10 pts	**Proficient – 8 pts**	**Developing – 6 pts**	**Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below**
-Clearly addresses all three reflection questions. -Specific and thoughtful explanation. -Meaningfully summarizes the	-Addresses all prompts, but one response is too vague/ not clearly explained. -The conclusion is too brief but addresses most aspects.	-Addresses only 1–2 prompts OR responses are too brief to illustrate reflection. -The conclusion is present, but doesn't clearly summarize project.	-Reflection missing key elements or lacks meaningful engagement. -Conclusion is missing.

Excellent – 10 pts	Proficient – 8 pts	Developing – 6 pts	Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below
conclusion of the project.			

APA References (10 points)

The refence list should include ALL sources references in the poster, in alphabetical order. (Note: For those familiar with APA formatting and curious, we will not worry about hanging indent format, as it is particularly difficult in PowerPoint.) Each source in a reference list should include information about the author, date, article title, journal information, pages (or Article ID), and DOI. Each section of a reference has specific formatting rules, and is listed in a specific order.

- Authors: Last Name, Initials; not italicized; in the order provided in the original paper
    - Scheuler, B. L.
    - Scheuler, B. L & Turner, R.
    - Scheuler, B. L, Turner, R. & Bartholomay, E.
    - This process is repeated for up to 21 authors (after that, there are extra rules. See Dr. Scheuler for help in this case)
- Date: year listed in parentheses, followed by a period.
    - (2025).
- Article Title: Write full title, only capitalizing proper nouns or word that begin a sentence/ sentence fragment; not italicized; end with a period
    - The benefits of health psychology: A comprehensive review utilizing the BRIEF Inventory.
- Journal Title: Beginning letter of each word capitalized; italicized; separated from volume/ issue information with a comma
    - *The Health Psychology Bulletin,*
- Volume and Issue: Volume number is italicized; issue number is not italicized, but is placed in parentheses; use a comma to separate from the page numbers or article ID; note: there is no space between the volume and parentheses
    - *25*(12),

- Page numbers: Write page range with a dash in between numbers; not italicized; end with a period.
    - 12-27.
    - Note- some online articles will have an article ID instead of page numbers. In that case, where page numbers would go, you will write "Article" and the ID number
        - Article 23456
- DOI: DOI included as hyperlink (will contain the entire URL)
    - https://doi.org/10.1017/S0144686X20001932

All this information is listed back-to-back for each source. Altogether, it will look like:

Rybaczewska, M., & Sparks, L. (2022). Ageing consumers and e-commerce activities. *Ageing and Society, 42*(8), 1879–1898. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0144686X20001932

NOTE: If a source is NOT peer-reviewed, it will NOT count as one of your 3 sources.

If you need help with formatting your references, please email Dr. Scheuler promptly, to schedule a time to walk through formatting fixes. To help, you can also edit your information into the following examples:

Author, A. A., & Author, B. B (20##). Article title goes here. *Journal Title Goes Here, #*(#), #–#. (replace this line with DOI link)

OR, if the article has an ID instead of page numbers:

Author, A. A., & Author, B. B (20##). Article title goes here. *Journal Title Goes Here, #*(#), Article #. (replace this line with DOI link)

And for your AI source, you can edit this citation:

ChatGPT. (2025, September 28). *Citing ChatGPT in APA for beginners* [generative AI chat]. ChatGPT. https://chatgpt.com/c/68da0b8e-bfbc-8321-a026-825dcc2ee250

Points in Rubric:

Excellent – 10 pts	**Proficient – 8 pts**	**Developing – 6 pts**	**Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below**
-at least 3 articles are peer-reviewed completely follow APA guidelines for each element. -References are in alphabetical order. -In-text citations match references.	-Multiple minor APA error	-Multiple serious APA errors. -1 reference missing	-Contains 0-1 peer-reviewed articles in references. -No in-text citations included.

Note: I will complete this checklist for your peer-reviewed references, so feel free to use it to check your own:

___/1 – Alphabetic order

___/0.5 – Article 1 in-text citation
___/0.5 – Article 1 author(s)
___/0.3 – Article 1 date
___/0.35 – Article 1 article title
___/0.35 – Article 1 journal title
___/0.35 – Article 1 vol. & issue
___/0.25 – Article 1 page range/ ID
___/0.4 – Article 1 DOI

___/0.5 – Article 2 in-text citation
___/0.5 – Article 2 author(s)
___/0.3 – Article 2 date
___/0.35 – Article 2 article title
___/0.35 – Article 2 journal title
___/0.35 – Article 2 vol. & issue
___/0.25 – Article 2 page range/ ID
___/0.4 – Article 2 DOI

___/0.5 – Article 3 in-text citation
___/0.5 – Article 3 author(s)
___/0.3 – Article 3 date
___/0.35 – Article 3 article title
___/0.35 – Article 3 journal title
___/0.35 – Article 3 vol. & issue
___/0.25 – Article 3 page range/ ID
___/0.4 – Article 3 DOI

Poster Design (5 points)

You MUST use the template to create your poster, to ensure consistency in grading across students. Rather than filling the poster with large blocks of text, focus on listing key information. You will expand on this information in your presentation. Use in-text citations when appropriate. Please check thoroughly for grammatical errors and unclear sentences. The entire poster should be in the font and text size of the template. All content must be legible when presenting (you may elect to zoom in on the poster sections as you present). The content must be clearly separated, with an understandable flow between sections. Selections in colors, fonts, and images must not hinder the ability to see or interpret the poster.

Points in Rubric:

Excellent – 5 pts	**Proficient – 4 pts**	**Developing – 3 pts**	**Needs Improvement – 2 pts or below**
-Poster is visually appealing, professional, and easy to read. -Information is organized logically and follows the required project structure. -Text is concise and appropriate for a conference-style poster. -Figures, graphs, and visual elements enhance understanding of the project. -Font sizes, spacing, and color choices promote readability.	- Poster is organized and readable. -Minor issues with layout, spacing, or visual balance. -Visuals are present and generally support the content.	- Organization is somewhat difficult to follow. -Sections appear crowded, sparse, or inconsistently arranged. -Visual elements are limited, poorly integrated, or difficult to interpret.	- Poster lacks clear organization. -Visual presentation is difficult to read or understand. -Required sections are difficult to locate or missing. -Limited attention to readability or professional appearance.

Step 5: Recording Presentation

After you complete your poster, you will record your presentation. You can record your presentation through PowerPoint directly, or use an external platform like Zoom. A walkthrough of recording in PowerPoint will be provided in Canvas. The recording should be around 5 minutes, with 30 seconds of flexibility (so, the acceptable range is 4 minutes and 30 seconds to 5 minutes and 30 seconds). I HIGHLY encourage you to practice your presentation before recording, just like you would for an in-class presentation (Hint: still record it each time, and if you like a practice presentation, you can keep it). Your presentation will be graded on two aspects: content coverage and presentation delivery (see below for details). **NOTE:** If you submit an image/ document of the poster instead of a recording, the highest grade you can get is a 50%. For each section, I incorporate what you say verbally with what is on the poster, which typically works in the student's favor (if you say something that should have been written, I will award partial credit). On the flip side, if you do not record the presentation at all, it will substantially hurt your grade. Not recording the presentation is the equivalent of not showing up for an in-class presentation.

The first aspect you will be graded on in your presentation is the **content coverage**. To receive maximum points, please make sure you address every section (except the references). The poster should have the key information, your presentation should EXPLAIN the key information, providing more details than the brief bullet points on your poster. This means that you should NOT be reading off your slide. You SHOULD be describing each stage, using the points on your poster to remind you what you want to say. You did the work, so describe the work you did. Be sure that you explain each stage enough for another classmate to understand what you did and why. Practice presenting so that you can have a clear flow from one topic to the next, with an adequate (but not over-abundant amount of time spent on each section).

Points in Rubric:

Excellent – 10 pts	**Proficient – 8 pts**	**Developing – 6 pts**	**Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below**
- Follows the required poster organization. -Thoroughly explains all sections of the project. -Provides additional explanation beyond what appears on the poster. -Information flows logically from section to section.	-Covers all major sections. -Minor omissions or limited elaboration in one area. -Generally organized and easy to follow.	- Multiple sections receive minimal explanation. -Some required components are unclear or briefly addressed. -Organization is inconsistent.	- Several required sections are not explained. -Presentation lacks logical organization. -Important project components omitted or inaccurate.

The second aspect you will be graded on in your presentation is the **delivery** of your presentation. You should speak clearly and professionally (as if you were giving a presentation to a class or at a conference). Please do your best to minimize filler words (“uh”, “um”, etc.). You should be familiar enough with your poster that you can present smoothly, without needing to pause to read over your poster. You should listen back to the recording to make sure the audio was recorded correctly. Do NOT wait until last minute to record your lecture, in case there are any issues with the audio. Additionally, you should check to make sure your recording is within the 5 minute +/- 30 seconds window. The benefit of a recording instead of a class presentation is that you can re-attempt as many times as you leave time for, so please use that aspect to your advantage.

Points in Rubric:

Excellent – 10 pts	Proficient – 8 pts	Developing – 6 pts	Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below
- Recording is clear and professional. -Speaker maintains a conversational tone and explains the project rather than reading directly from the poster. -Audio is easy to hear and understand. -Presentation remains within the 5-minute time limit. -Poster is visible throughout the presentation.	- Generally clear presentation. -Some reliance on reading from the poster. -Minor audio or pacing issues. -Slightly under or over the time limit (over 30 seconds).	- Heavy reliance on reading the poster. -Frequent pauses, unclear explanations, or pacing issues. -Audio quality makes portions difficult to understand. -More than 1 minute outside the time limit.	- Presentation is difficult to understand. -Primarily reads text directly from the poster. -Significant audio/video problems. -Poster not visible for much of the presentation. -Substantially outside the time limit.

Policies

AI Use

The use of AI platforms is only permitted for the feedback section and MUST be appropriately cited. AI should not be used for any resources, information, planning, or explanation aspect of the project.

Late Policy

As per the syllabus, there will be a 10-point deduction for every day late. As students are aware of their project for multiple weeks, and the project is submitted online, extensions will not be granted based on events that occur the day the project is due.

Feedback Policy

Students will be graded in Canvas, so you will be able to see how many points you earn per section in the rubric. If you would like detailed feedback alongside your grade, you must notify Dr. Scheuler when you submit your project.